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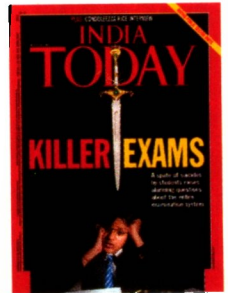
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We often think of India's young as the lucky generation. Unlike those just a decade ago, the teenagers of this millennium are growing up in a dynamic, changing country, with a range of options before them in careers, leisure and lifestyle. But a profusion of choices seems to have produced a generation of young people who end up being confused and conflicted and, at the very extreme, more prone to taking their own lives.

Every year around examination time, we read tragic stories of anxious or unsuccessful students trying to commit suicide over academic failure. The increase in teenage suicides has moved beyond being just a few sporadic cases into a disturbing trend. India actually tops the world in adolescent suicides, with some studies saying there are as many as 16 cases a day. In March alone, over 100 teenagers in India killed themselves. For a country that traditionally prides itself on the security that comes from close family ties, this is a sign that something is going seriously wrong.

The grind of our academics and examination system and the pressure to live up to parental expectation is a crushing burden. To an extent, our young have always lived with them but today the pressure to excel in a highly competitive and aspirational society is far greater. This has led not only to more anxious children but also to the phenomenon of the 'pushover' parents: the overworked, stressed adults who cannot say no to any of their child's demands. Consequently, the young have what one doctor called, "a distorted sense of entitlement" which makes them unable to handle failure or adversity.



Our March '05 cover

Adolescence has always been a confusing and emotional phase in everyone's life but in modern India it has acquired a dark side. For the first time the National Crime Records Bureau has included a new category in its grim listing of deaths and crimes: "Persons below 16 attempting suicide." Parliamentarians have called for the examination system to be changed. There is another key factor though, in the high rate of teen suicides that cannot be changed by formal legislation: the fact that parents regularly ignore tell-tale signs of depression in their children that end up leading to suicide.

Our cover story this week was researched and reported by Deputy Editor Damayanti Datta, who spoke to teenagers and their parents, counsellors, teachers and doctors about this worrying phenomenon. The story finds out what it is that persuades the young that adulthood is not worth waiting for and, as importantly, what parents need to look out for. Datta says, "The wastage of young lives is actually a testimony to us, of the world that we have created for ourselves."

This squandering of hundreds of teenage lives out of fear and worry, is a national tragedy. It can be sought to be addressed through change in our educational patterns but it can only be most effectively tackled inside the home. Indeed, this is a wake-up call for us all.

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)